STOP.



Host only. Do not open until the reveal.

This file names the culprit. Don't open it, don't print-preview it. **Want to guess too?** Keep it closed, cast your own ballot, and when every ballot is in, hand this file to a player to read Script 5 aloud (page 5).

The Candlewick Costume Ball Murder

A Cozy Halloween Murder Mystery Party Game

6–14 PLAYERS · AGES 12+ · PRINTABLE PDF

SOLUTION · HOST ONLY · OPEN LAST

CLUE & CANDLE GAMES

The Solution

THE CULPRIT

Marlo Quince, the master chandler

How: at about 8:28 Marlo took Jory's fox mask from hook 3 and Briar's sleep drops from the sewing bag on hook 5. Wearing a black cloak and the fox mask, Marlo filled Vesper's pumpkin cup at the gallery kettle, added the drops and handed it to Vesper at about 8:35, then hid the mask and bottle in the Stockroom bin.

Why: Marlo had secretly sold the Hall's six antique brass candle molds for $1,800 and replaced them with fakes. Vesper found out and gave Marlo until nine o'clock to confess.

The clue chain (6 steps)

Step	Source	What it proves
1	E2 + E5 + Booklet 15, Round 1	The sleep drops were in Vesper's pumpkin cup only (E2, E5). At about 8:35 Hadley saw someone in a long black cloak and a fox mask carry a steaming pumpkin cup to Vesper. Whoever wore the fox mask at 8:35 is the culprit.
2	E3 + E6 + Booklet 14, Round 1	The fox mask was Jory's, but Jory left it on hook 3 in the Coat Room at 8:25 (E3) and was on the terrace, bare-faced, at 8:30 and 8:36 with Perry beside them (E6). Someone else took the mask from the Coat Room.
3	E1 + E9 + Booklet 12, Round 2	The figure walked back toward the Back Stairs (Perry saw it at 8:36), the only way down to the workshop floor (E1). The mask turned up in the Stockroom bin at the foot of those stairs, wrapped around Briar's empty sleep-drops bottle, taken from the bag on hook 5 (E9, E3).
4	E9 + Booklet 13, Round 3 + Cast List	Inside the mask's eye holes: gold face paint (E9). Face paint rubs off inside a mask (Briar, 13 R3). Only two guests wore gold face paint: Darcy Wickliffe and Marlo Quince.
5	E7 + E10 + Booklet 10, Round 1	Darcy stood in the parade line-up from 8:30 to 8:45, ticked at every roll call (E7). Marlo claims to have worked in the Dipping Room all evening, but the slate by the vats reads "Out 8:20 · Back 8:45" (E10). Marlo's alibi is false.
6	E11 + E12 + Booklet 11, Round 3	The motive: the brass molds were fakes, the appraiser was coming, and the seller "has until nine" (E11). The real molds were sold at the Back Stairs door by someone with their own key (E12). Marlo holds those keys and is the one who looked after the molds (11 R3).

Why Not the Others?

13 SUSPECTS CLEARED

Suspect	Why they looked suspicious	Why it wasn't them
11 Darcy Wickliffe	The heir; owes $4,000; argued with Vesper at 8:15; wears gold face paint.	On the stage in the parade line-up 8:30–8:45, ticked at every roll call (E7).
12 Perry Lanthorn	The Lantern Ghost: fishing line (E4) and the "Pe" slip (E8); on a ladder by the windows.	On the terrace in both photos, 8:30 and 8:36 (E6). The ghost was a harmless stunt.
13 Briar Fallow	The sleep drops were Briar's (E9); secret costumes for four entrants.	On the stage line-up 8:30–8:45 (E7); wears no face paint.
14 Jory Greaves	It was Jory's fox mask; Jory's field was to become parking.	Bare-faced on the terrace at 8:30 and 8:36 (E6); no face paint.
15 Hadley Cresswell	In the gallery at 8:35; secretly read Vesper's notes.	Perry saw Hadley and the cloaked figure as two people (12 R2); no face paint.
16 Auden Pryor	Kept the borrowed ledger; wanted the archive.	Alone in the library; no gold face paint.
17 Bexley Applegate	Filled Vesper's cup at 8:20; losing the cider contract.	At the urn in the front hall all evening; the urn cider was fine (E5).
18 Corin Thimble	The band was to be replaced by recordings.	On the musicians' balcony; no gold face paint.
19 Larkin Hearthstone	The museum café would end the pie stall.	In the kitchen across the front hall; no gold face paint.
20 Teagan Bramwell	Holds forty keys; might lose the job.	At the front gate; Teagan's Back Stairs key was lost a month ago.
21 Ainsley Duskwood	Wears a black cloak; Vesper called the act "nonsense."	In the conservatory with a queue; a silver mask, no gold paint.
22 Merritt Oxley	Advised the council to refuse the gift.	In the study with the door shut; heard the footsteps go by.
23 Wynn Pennywhistle	Selling the parade photos in secret.	In the portrait room upstairs; no gold face paint.

Optional characters (16–23) are cleared by step 4: none of them wore gold face paint. The case never depends on them.

The Lantern Ghost, Explained

NOTHING SUPERNATURAL

The Lantern Ghost is a red herring. It had nothing to do with Vesper's cup, and it was made by an innocent guest: **Perry Lanthorn**, the lantern-maker.

- **How it works:** a tiny lantern with a battery tea light hangs from a small brass hook on clear fishing line (E4), strung outside the gallery from window one to window nine. From the terrace, Perry pulls the line by hand, so the light glides past every window and "winks out" behind the last one.
- **The proof:** the coil of line behind the curtain at window one (E4), the stockroom slip for a tea light, fishing line and a brass hook signed "Pe" (E8), and the Gazette photos of Perry on a stepladder holding something thin and shiny (E6).
- **Why Perry did it:** Perry has flown the ghost every Halloween for eleven years to keep the legend alive. This year Vesper planned to replace the gallery's real lanterns with electric bulbs, so Perry flew it once more, hoping a famous sighting in the Gazette would save them.
- **Why it doesn't matter:** the ghost flew at 8:48. Vesper had already taken the cup at about 8:35 and was seen sipping it at 8:36.

The other red herrings

- **The fox mask** points at Jory, but Jory was on camera without it.
- **The sleep drops** point at Briar, but Briar never left the stage.
- **The heir with gold face paint** points at Darcy, but Darcy was ticked at every roll call.
- **The guest in the gallery** points at Hadley, but Hadley was the witness, not the figure.

> **KEY EVIDENCE FOR SCORING**
>
> The clue chain on page 2: E1, E2, E3, E5, E6, E7, E9, E10, E11 and E12. Each one written on a ballot earns 1 point (up to 3). E4 and E8 (the Lantern Ghost) score nothing.

Script 5 · The Reveal

A VOLUNTEER READS ALOUD

READ ALOUD

Thank you, everyone. Here is what happened at the Candlewick Costume Ball. The town doctor found sleep drops in Vesper's pumpkin cup, and nowhere else. At about twenty-five to nine, Hadley saw someone in a long black cloak and a fox mask carry a steaming pumpkin cup to Vesper's chair. Vesper said, "Oh, thank you." Vesper thought it was Jory.

But Jory had hung that fox mask on hook 3 at twenty-five past eight, and the Gazette camera shows Jory on the terrace, bare-faced, at half past and again at 8:36. Someone took the mask from the Coat Room, and the sleep drops from Briar's sewing bag on the very next hook. The figure walked back toward the Back Stairs, and the mask turned up at the foot of those stairs, in the Stockroom bin.

Inside the mask: gold face paint. Only two guests wore gold face paint tonight. Darcy was on the stage, ticked at every roll call from half past eight to quarter to nine. And the slate beside the wax vats, in the Dipping Room, reads "Out 8:20, Back 8:45."

The culprit is Marlo Quince. Two winters ago Marlo sold the Hall's six brass candle molds and put fakes in the case. Vesper found out and said: tell everyone at nine, or I will. Marlo chose the fox mask instead. And the Lantern Ghost? That was Perry, with a tea light and some fishing line, saving the lanterns one last time. Marlo, please take a bow. And everyone: raise your cider, your cocoa or your punch to Vesper, and to the Candlewick Costume Ball.

THEN

Hand back to the Detective to score the ballots (page 6) and give out the awards.

Scoring & Awards

Ballot line	Correct answer	Points
Who did it?	Marlo Quince	3
How?	Sleep drops (Briar's) in Vesper's pumpkin cup of cider, delivered at about 8:35 while wearing Jory's fox mask and a black cloak. Any answer naming the sleep drops and the cup.	2
Why?	To stop Vesper revealing that Marlo had sold the brass candle molds and replaced them with fakes. Any answer about the molds.	2
Key clue	One point each (up to 3) for any clue-chain card: E1, E2, E3, E5, E6, E7, E9, E10, E11 or E12	3
Best possible score		10

Half points

- "How" that names the cup but not the drops (or the drops but not the cup): 1 point.
- "Why" that says "Vesper was about to expose a secret" without the molds: 1 point.

The awards (file 34)

- **Best Detective:** the highest ballot score. Ties go to the most correct evidence numbers.
- **Best Costume:** the Costume Parade winner (vote by applause, if you haven't already).
- **Best Bluffer:** vote by applause. Marlo is eligible, especially if nobody guessed.
- **Spookiest Alibi:** vote by applause for the strangest story of the night. Perry and the Lantern Ghost are strong contenders.

PHOTO MOMENT

Line everyone up under the CANDLEWICK COSTUME BALL banner with the photo props, culprit in the middle holding an empty pumpkin cup.

THANK YOU

We hope the Candlewick Costume Ball gave your party a story to retell for years. Questions? chenphien@gmail.com · Clue & Candle Games